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APPS



Instagram is developing a feature that helps users find shared interests

Instagram is working on a feature called “Picks” that aims to help users find common interests. The Meta-owned social network confirmed to TechCrunch that Picks is an internal prototype and isn’t being tested externally.

The feature was first spotted by [reverse engineer Alessandro Paluzzi](#), who often finds unreleased features while they’re still under development.

According to screenshots shared by Paluzzi, people select their favorite movies, books, TV shows, games, and music, or their “Picks.” Instagram then finds overlaps with friends who chose the same things.

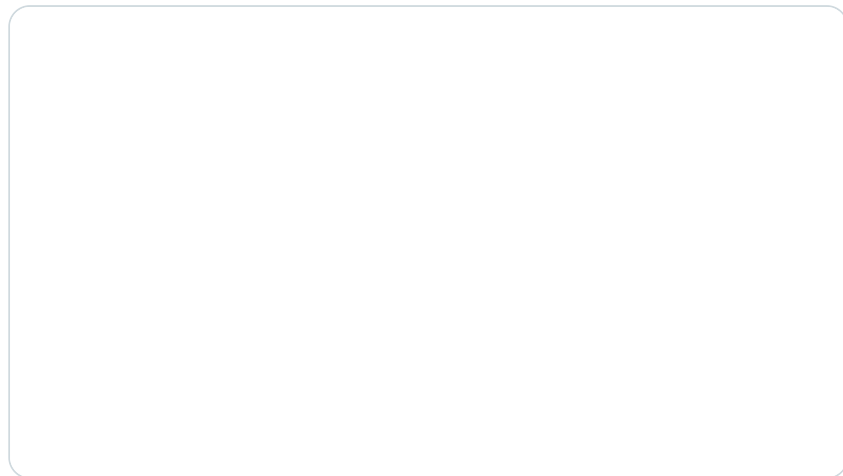
Alessandro Paluzzi

@alex193a · [Follow](#)



[#Instagram](#) is working on Picks 🙄

i Add what you're into and find overlap with friends who are all about it too

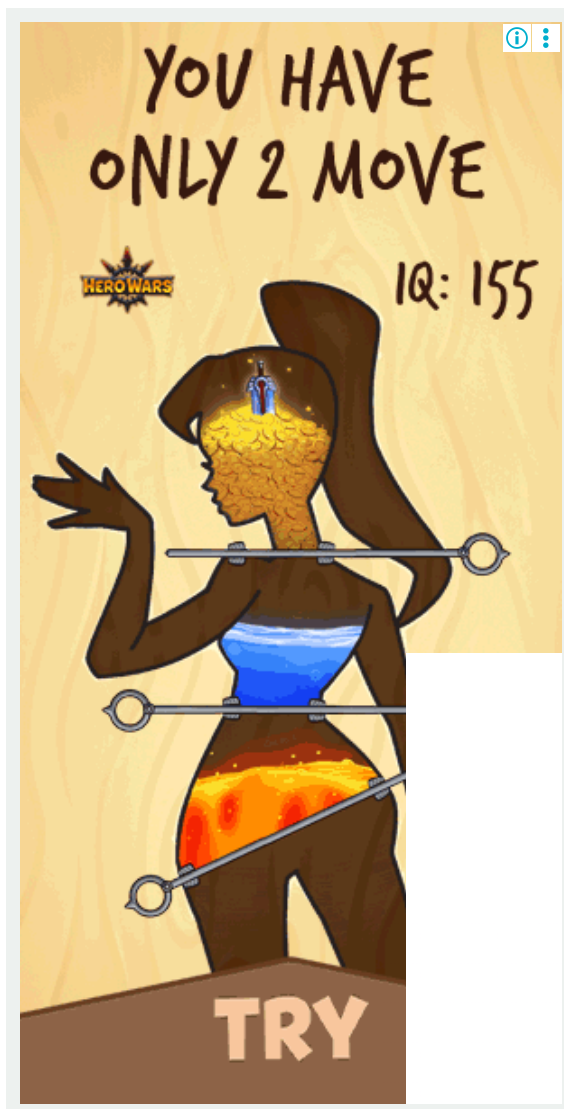


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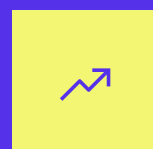
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Instagram head Adam Mosseri said earlier this year that the social network was going to focus on creativity and connection in 2025. “To help people connect with friends over the things they discover on Instagram, we’re going to double down on messaging, make consuming content more interactive and social, and explore new ways to connect with friends,” Mosseri wrote in a January [Instagram post](#).

Of course, not everyone will welcome Picks, as it adds yet another feature to an already overcrowded app. Instagram is facing backlash following the launch of [Instagram Map](#), with many [users saying](#) they [never wanted](#) the feature in the first place.

As with any other feature in development, it’s not known when or if Instagram plans to officially roll out Picks.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter |

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporter at MobileSyrup. Aisha...

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APPS



TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

Aisha Malik — 6:00 AM PDT · August 19, 2025

In a move reminiscent of Facebook's early days, TikTok is launching a new feature that allows college students to find and connect with others on their campus. The feature, called Campus Verification, lets users add their college campus to their TikTok profile and browse a list of students at their school.

To access the feature, users need to navigate to their profile and tap the "Add school" button. From there, they need to enter their school name and then select their graduation year.

To verify that they actually go to the school they entered, they need to provide their academic email address. Once complete, their college name and graduation year will be displayed on their profile.

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Users can then browse their school's page, filter by graduation year, and view all of the users who have added the school to their profile. They can also sort the users list to show the most-followed users first.

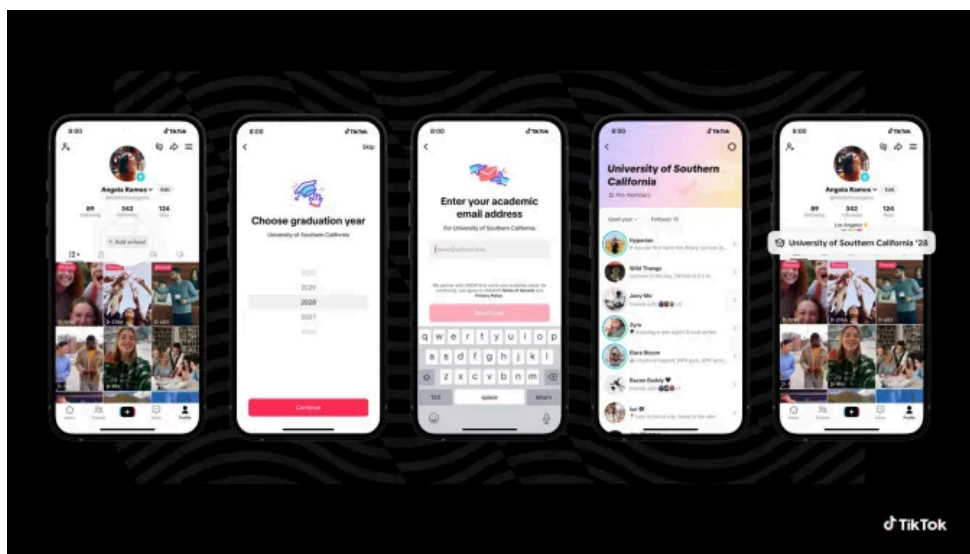


IMAGE CREDITS:TIKTOK

The feature is available across more than 6,000 universities through TikTok's partnership with [UNiDAYS](#), a student verification platform that confirms student status.

TikTok says the idea behind the feature is to turn its platform into a hub for real-world connections and belonging on campus, which is essentially what Facebook's original mission was when it launched in 2004 as a way for Harvard students to connect with one another.

TikTok's new feature could be a welcome addition for college students looking to connect with others on campus. However, it also raises concerns about digital privacy, as it could make it easier for users to track others online. Of course, the feature is optional, so those who prefer to keep their TikTok presence separate from their student life can choose to simply not add their school to their profile.

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It's worth noting that the launch comes as Instagram was [spotted testing a similar feature](#) last year that would allow users to display their school info and graduation year on their profile and connect with other students. It's unknown if the feature was scrapped or if the Meta-owned platform still plans to roll it out.

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Hank Green's Focus Friend app is climbing the App Store charts — and it's extremely cute

Amanda Silberling — 10:36 AM PDT · August 18, 2025



You must stay focused. You cannot open TikTok, or Instagram, or whatever little phone games you like to play. If you fail, you will make an anthropomorphic bean very sad, because its knitting project depends on your ability to stay focused.

This is the premise of [Focus Friend](#), a productivity app created by [Honey B Games](#) and [Hank Green](#), the longtime online creator/entrepreneur/educator/[sock salesman](#). Though the app was soft launched last month, Focus Friend is only now

IMAGE CREDITS: FOCUS FRIEND

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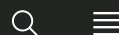


TikTok's latest feature lets college students find and connect with classmates

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designate which apps to block,

But what makes Focus Friend different is that it assigns you a new friend — a little bean — which you can give a cute name,

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like Garbanzo, or Susan Bean Anthony, or Eda (it's short for Edamame).

Your bean needs help focusing on its knitting. And it can only focus if you refrain from opening the apps that distract you from your work. If you successfully complete your focus session, your bean will give you in-game points (socks), which you can use to buy decorations for its room — because the only thing more motivating than helping a bean knit is to buy it a cute poster for its wall.

Focus Friend has a lot in common with [Finch](#), a popular self-care app that incentivizes users to maintain healthy habits by giving them a virtual bird companion. Your bird grows when you complete certain tasks that you set for yourself, like drinking water, brushing your teeth, or cleaning your room. Like the Tamagotchis of yore, these apps exploit our desire to protect a cute bundle of pixels by doing stuff that's good for us.

Focus Friend is functional as a free app, but you can pay to give your bean different skins — you can make your bean look like a cat (a “Kitt-ney Bean”) or a jelly bean, for example. There's also a subscription that allows your bean to knit scarves, which can be exchanged for premium decorations. Green [posted](#) on Bluesky that Focus Friend is “very much trying to be an ad-free experience because the mobile ad ecosystem kinda blows.” But the app still has to make money to compensate the employees who brought our beans to life.



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Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer | [X](#) [reddit](#) [in](#)

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also written for...

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Texas attorney general accuses Meta, Character.AI of misleading kids with mental health claims

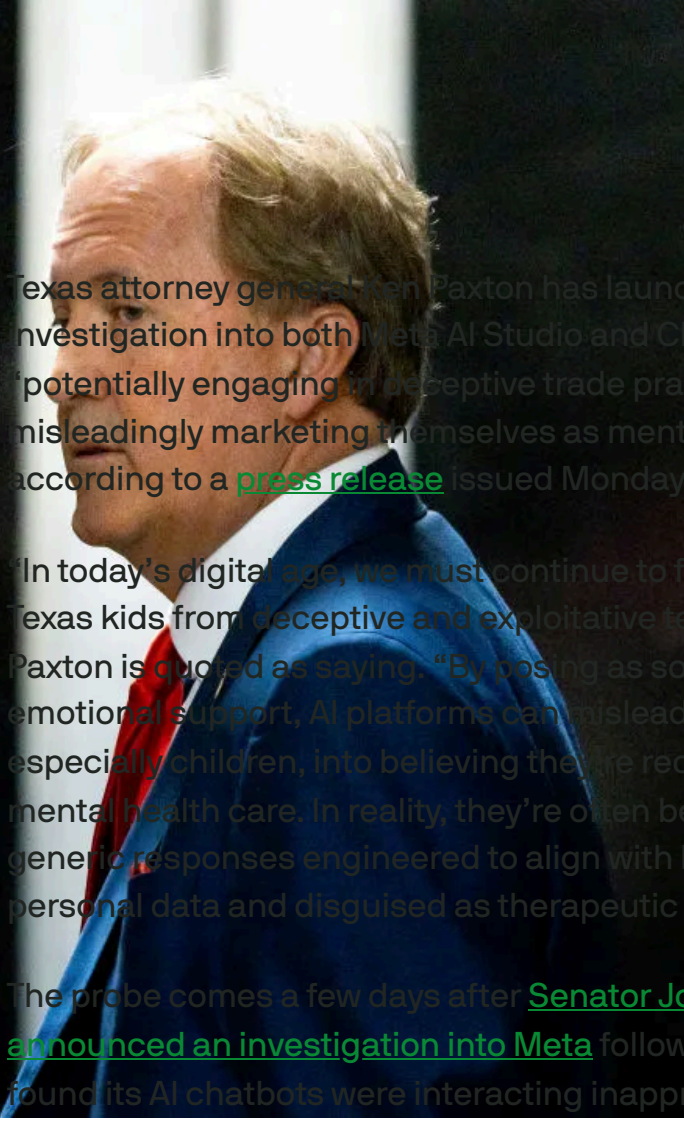


IMAGE CREDITS: GETTY IMAGES

Texas attorney general Ken Paxton has launched an investigation into both Meta AI Studio and Character.AI for “potentially engaging in deceptive trade practices and misleadingly marketing themselves as mental health tools,” according to a [press release](#) issued Monday.

“In today’s digital age, we must continue to fight to protect Texas kids from deceptive and exploitative technology,” Paxton is quoted as saying. “By posing as sources of emotional support, AI platforms can mislead vulnerable users, especially children, into believing they’re receiving legitimate mental health care. In reality, they’re often being fed recycled, generic responses engineered to align with harvested personal data and disguised as therapeutic advice.”

The probe comes a few days after [Senator Josh Hawley](#) [announced an investigation into Meta](#) following a report that found its AI chatbots were interacting inappropriately with children, including by flirting.

The Texas Attorney General’s office has accused Meta and [Character.AI](#) of creating AI personas that present as “professional therapeutic tools, despite lacking proper medical credentials or oversight.”

Among the millions of AI personas available on Character.AI, one user-created bot called [Psychologist](#) has seen high demand among the startup’s young users. Meanwhile, Meta doesn’t offer therapy bots for kids, but there’s nothing stopping children from using the Meta AI chatbot or one of the personas created by third parties for therapeutic purposes.

“We clearly label AIs, and to help people better understand their limitations, we include a disclaimer that responses are generated by AI — not people,” Meta spokesperson Ryan Daniels told TechCrunch. “These AIs aren’t licensed professionals and our models are designed to direct users to seek qualified medical or safety professionals when appropriate.”

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However, TechCrunch noted that many children may not understand — or may simply ignore — such disclaimers. We have asked Meta what additional safeguards it takes to protect minors using its chatbots.

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For its part, Character includes prominent disclaimers in every chat to remind users that a “Character” is not a real person, and everything they say should be treated as fiction, according to a Character.AI spokesperson. She noted that the startup adds additional disclaimers when users create Characters with the words “psychologist,” “therapist,” or “doctor” to not rely on them for any type of professional advice.

In his statement, Paxton also observed that though AI chatbots assert confidentiality, their “terms of service reveal that user interactions are logged, tracked, and exploited for targeted advertising and algorithmic development, raising serious concerns about privacy violations, data abuse, and false advertising.”

According to [Meta's privacy policy](#), Meta does collect prompts, feedback, and other interactions with AI chatbots and across Meta services to “improve AIs and related technology.” The policy doesn't explicitly say anything about advertising, but it does state that information can be shared with third parties, like search engines, for “more personalized outputs.” Given Meta's ad-based business model, this effectively translates to targeted advertising.

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Character.AI's [privacy policy](#) also highlights how the startup logs identifiers, demographics, location information, and more information about the user, including browsing behavior and app usage platforms. It tracks users across ads on TikTok, YouTube, Reddit, Facebook, Instagram, and Discord, which it may link to a user's account. This information is used to train AI, tailor the service to personal preferences, and provide targeted advertising, including sharing data with advertisers and analytics providers.

A Character.AI spokesperson said the startup is “just beginning to explore targeted advertising on the platform” and that those explorations “have not involved using the content of chats on the platform.”

The spokesperson also confirmed that the same privacy policy applies to all users, even teenagers.

TechCrunch has asked Meta such tracking is done on children, too, and will update this story if we hear back.

Both Meta and Character say their services aren't designed for children under 13. That said, Meta has come under fire for failing to police accounts created by kids under 13, and Character's kid-friendly characters are clearly designed to attract younger users. The startup's CEO, Karandeep Anand, has even said that his [six-year-old daughter](#) uses the platform's chatbots under his supervision.

That type of data collection, targeted advertising, and algorithmic exploitation is exactly what legislation like KOSA (Kids Online Safety Act) is meant to protect against. KOSA was teed up to pass last year with strong bipartisan support, but it stalled after major pushback from tech industry lobbyists. Meta in particular deployed a formidable lobbying machine, warning lawmakers that the bill's broad mandates would undercut its business model.

[KOSA was reintroduced](#) to the Senate in May 2025 by Senators Marsha Blackburn (R-TN) and Richard Blumenthal (D-CT).

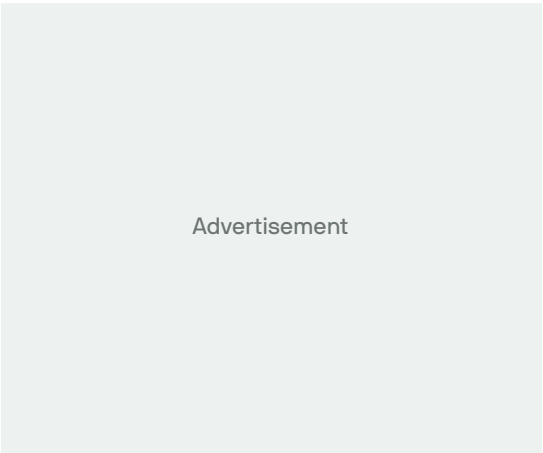
Paxton has issued civil investigative demands — legal orders that require a company to produce documents, data, or testimony during a government probe — to the companies to determine if they have violated Texas consumer protection laws.

This story was updated with comments from a Character.AI spokesperson.

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Senior Reporter |

Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch where she covers the business, policy, and emerging trends shaping artificial intelligence. H...

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